



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

A CREW works to remove and preserve valuable tiles at a burned home in Altadena last month. A new poll found that recent fires had a wide-reaching effect on the physical and mental health of L.A. County residents.

Staying put despite fires, stress

Most residents in Los Angeles County aren’t going anywhere and are satisfied with the region’s quality of life, poll says

BY LAURA J. NELSON

Despite widespread stress, smoke inhalation and other disruptions caused by the January wildfires, a majority of Los Angeles County residents are happy with their lives here and don’t plan to leave.

Fewer than 1 in 4 L.A. County residents are considering moving out of the area because of the fires, and fewer than 1 in 10 are seriously weighing that decision, according to a new poll from the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies co-sponsored by The Times.

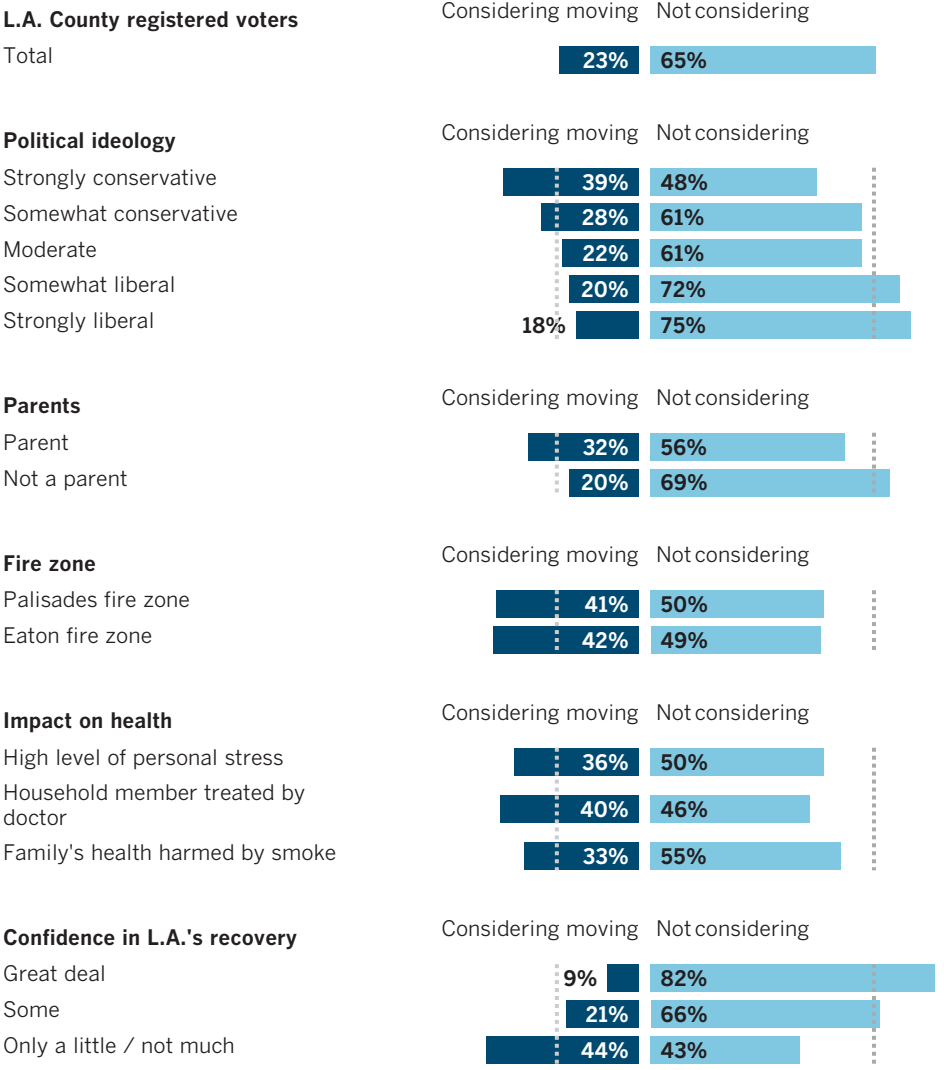
The poll found that 57% of residents are satisfied with the region’s quality of life, while more than 7 in 10 people are happy with their own neighborhood.

“This huge tragedy affected a lot of people in the county, and yet, the overall measures on the quality of life in Los Angeles are positive,” said Mark DiCamillo, director of the Berkeley IGS poll. “It’s the California lifestyle. A lot of people like it.”

The fires in Altadena and Pacific Palisades destroyed more than 13,000 homes and businesses and, in combination with smaller blazes in Hollywood, Studio City and Sylmar, forced the evacuation of nearly 200,000 people.

The poll found that the fires had a wide-reaching effect on the physical and mental health of county residents, including those who lived far from the disaster [See **Poll**, A5]

Almost a quarter of L.A. County residents considered moving out of the area because of the fires



Berkeley IGS poll of 5,184 Los Angeles County registered voters conducted online in English and Spanish from Feb. 17-26. Estimated overall margin of error is + / - 2 percentage points. The margin of error is greater for subgroups, including for people living in the burn zones.

HANNA SENDER Los Angeles Times

Army Corps knew water dump risky

Lawmakers and others pushed back against president’s ill-timed order for release, according to memo.

BY IAN JAMES

When President Trump called for the federal government to “maximize” water deliveries in California, commanders of the Army Corps of Engineers quickly found two dams where they could carry out that order. And even though the officials knew the water couldn’t be moved out of the Central Valley as Trump wished, they released billions of gallons anyway, according to a newly released government document.

The Feb. 3 memo by Col. Chad Caldwell, the corps’ regional commander, provides the most detailed account to date of how the agency responded to Trump’s order directing federal agencies to increase water deliveries in California. The document recounts how corps officials suddenly decided to dump water from the dams in January, and how they encountered questions and opposition from local water man-

agers and lawmakers, who were concerned that letting out water didn’t make sense and that the high flows posed risks of flooding.

“It was cavalier and an extremely high-risk decision, and wasteful,” said Ann Willis, California regional director of American Rivers, a nonprofit environmental organization.

Willis, who worked for the corps in 2007 and 2008, said there was no reason to dump water that farmers and cities were depending on, and that releasing water unexpectedly like this could have unleashed flooding and put people at risk.

“To intentionally create a situation where that could have been the outcome, it’s depraved and mind-blowing,” Willis said.

Indeed, many California water officials and experts agreed that the plan had the potential to be ruinous. Local water managers pushed back when they learned of the plan by corps officials to release water from the dams, telling the agency that the water wasn’t needed this time of year and that the abrupt surge of water could do damage.

In response to the concerns, the memo says, federal officials scaled back [See **Water**, A7]

Trump eviscerates Dept. of Education, lays off about half

BY HOWARD BLUME, JAWEED KALEEM AND JENNY GOLD

The Trump administration has begun dismantling the U.S. Department of Education by laying off about half of the agency’s employees, casting uncertainty over how — or whether — billions of federal dollars for California to help disadvantaged students and those with disabilities will be distributed, how college financial aid and student loans will be managed and how civil rights enforcement will be carried out.

In San Francisco, the regional branch of the department Office for Civil Rights — already backlogged with investigations into school-related discrimination — is expected to be closed, one of the broad effects of the layoffs that advocates say are sending tremors through school systems, including Los Angeles Unified.

“These reckless layoffs will sow chaos and confusion throughout our nation’s

public school system,” said Guillermo Mayer, president and chief executive of Public Advocates, a California-based law firm and advocacy group. “Instead of bolstering learning outcomes, the immediate effect of these actions is quite cruel. It forces millions of parents, especially parents of students with disabilities, to worry about whether their children will receive the services they need.”

L.A. school board member Kelly Gonez addressed the federal layoffs Wednesday.

“We serve one of the most diverse populations in the country,” Gonez said. “We’re proud of serving immigrant families, many students of color and students from low-income backgrounds. So it’s a direct attack on the students and families that make up the majority of our students, and that’s why the risk for potential harm is so great. While we’re still assessing, these are very concerning steps that we’re seeing.” [See **Education**, A10]

Answers emerge about Altadena fire failures

Disaster management officials didn’t receive timely orders to send alerts, sources say.

BY REBECCA ELLIS, TERRY CASTLEMAN AND GRACE TOOHEY

The Los Angeles County emergency management officials responsible for sending evacuation alerts were not instructed to notify west Altadena residents until

long after the Eaton fire had barreled into the area, according to two county officials not authorized to speak publicly.

County fire or sheriff’s officials appear to have failed to set the alerts in motion, leaving many west Altadena residents to flee as flames and terrifying swirls of embers closed in around them.

All 17 of the deaths from the Eaton fire occurred west of Lake Avenue, where residents did not receive an evacuation order until around 3:30 a.m. Jan. 8.

Neighborhoods east of Lake, closer to where the fire began, got their first evacuation alert around 6:40 p.m. Jan. 7 and continued to get alerts throughout the evening.

Both sections of the town, which is in an unincorporated part of L.A. County, were devastated by the blaze.

Until now, it was unclear if the Office of Emergency Management, which had one person sending evacuation orders for three different fires on a new alert sys-

tem that night, was warned that west Altadena was on fire but failed to send evacuation orders.

According to the two county officials, emergency management staffers said they were not told to issue an evacuation order until shortly before the 3:30 a.m. alert went out.

Fire, sheriff and emergency management officials were working together at a unified command center at the Rose Bowl the night of the fire. All three agencies [See **Alerts**, A5]

EPA to roll back landmark rules

The plan is “a dagger straight into the heart of the climate change religion,” its chief says. **NATION, A4**

Ohtani’s pitching return can wait

Dodgers want their two-way star to focus on hitting in early stages of the season. **SPORTS B10**

A high-stakes ‘Snow White’

Disney’s live-action redo is set to open after a series of culture-war clashes. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Showers.
L.A. Basin: 58/41. **B6**

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